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THE DHARMA OF MIDDLE POWERS

*Purposeful Statecraft, Strategic Balance
and Civilisational Responsibility*



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Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā
Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.

Abstract

The contemporary international order is entering a period of sustained strategic acceleration characterised by intensifying great-power rivalry, securitised economic interdependence, technological competition, and declining confidence in multilateral institutions. While these developments have generated renewed attention to the role of middle powers, existing analyses remain largely confined to material capabilities, coalition behaviour, or institutional balancing.

This paper proposes a civilisational framework for understanding middle-power statecraft through the concept of the Dharma of Middle Powers. Drawing upon the Indian concepts of *Dharma*, *Rajas*, *Śānta Rajas*, *Rāja Dharma*, and *Maṇḍala*, it argues that the contemporary international system is best understood as a *rajasic* age, one defined not by systemic collapse but by accelerating competition without proportion. The strategic challenge, therefore, is not to arrest dynamism but to discipline it.

The paper argues that middle powers possess a distinctive stabilising role because they combine material capability with institutional credibility and coalition-building capacity. Their comparative advantage lies neither in hegemonic dominance nor strategic passivity, but in exercising disciplined dynamism: strengthening domestic resilience, pursuing strategic autonomy through diversified partnerships, reforming multilateral institutions, and exercising influence proportionate to capability. In this framework, Dharma functions not as moral idealism but as a structural principle of restraint that aligns power with responsibility, while Mandala provides a realist vocabulary for flexible coalition-building under conditions of competitive interdependence.

The paper concludes by extending the classical concept of *Rāja Dharma* into *Viśva Dharma*, arguing that middle powers increasingly bear responsibility not merely for national prosperity but for preserving the stability of an interconnected international order. In a *rājasic* age, the Dharma of middle powers is neither to suppress competition nor to imitate hegemonic rivalry, but to cultivate *Śānta Rājas*, disciplined energy directed toward a more stable and proportionate international equilibrium

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The Dharma of the Middle Powers

Order, Restraint, and Responsibility in a Rajasic Age

Recent reporting in *Financial Times* and *The Economist* captures the tonal shift of the present moment: transatlantic mistrust, intensifying rhetoric of European strategic autonomy, and electoral consolidation in Japan enabling expanded defence capacity. *Financial Times* describes Germany's distancing from Washington as structural rather than episodic, driven by economic securitisation and unilateral recalibration.¹ *Financial Times* reports President Emmanuel Macron urging Europe not to "bow" to American pressure amid mounting trade and defence tensions.² *The Economist* frames the continent's posture as a state of geopolitical emergency requiring institutional recalibration.³

Parallel developments in East Asia reinforce this trajectory. Japan's electoral consolidation under Sanae Takaichi is analysed as enabling expanded defence capacity within an alliance-embedded framework.⁴ Across these accounts, a consistent pattern emerges: securitised economics, alliance friction, defence modernisation cycles, restoration rhetoric, and intensifying technological competition.⁵

The risk is not systemic collapse. It is acceleration without proportion.

In his 2026 Davos address, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney characterised the moment not as gradual transition but as rupture.⁶ The rules-based order, long treated as stabilising architecture, no longer functions as advertised. Integration has become leverage; institutions are bypassed; economic interdependence is weaponised. Invoking Vaclav Havel's metaphor of "living within a lie," Carney suggested that middle powers had long participated in ritual affirmation of rules they recognised as unevenly enforced.⁷ That fiction, he argued, has expired.

His warning is stark: nostalgia is not strategy. The question is no longer how to restore a familiar order, but how to act with clarity inside a candidly competitive one.

¹ Anne-Sylvaine Chassany and Laura Pitel, "Germany's Painful Estrangement from the US," *Financial Times*, February 10, 2026.

² Leila Abboud, "Macron Urges EU Not to 'Bow' to US Aggression," *Financial Times*, February 11, 2026.

³ "Emmanuel Macron Declares a European State of Emergency," *The Economist*, February 13, 2026.

⁴ Leo Lewis, "Takaichi Wins Supermajority in Japan Poll," *Financial Times*, February 10, 2026.

⁵ "How Japan's Prime Minister Will Use Her Massive New Mandate," *The Economist*, February 13, 2026.

⁶ Mark Carney, Address at the World Economic Forum Annual Meeting, Davos, January 2026.

⁷ Václav Havel, "The Power of the Powerless," in *Living in Truth* (London: Faber & Faber, 1987).

The Rajasic Condition of Contemporary Geopolitics

In classical Indian thought, *rajas* denotes dynamism, ambition, activity, and expansion.⁸ It is kinetic energy that drives assertion and transformation.

Contemporary geopolitics displays distinctly *rajasic* qualities:

- Securitised trade and technology regimes
- Defence modernisation cycles across major economies
- Strategic autonomy rhetoric in Europe
- Industrial policy activism in the United States and China
- Prestige-driven diplomacy among emerging powers

This is not systemic paralysis (*tamas*). Nor is it equilibrium grounded in proportion (*sattva*). It is high-energy competition.

The modern international system itself was forged in prolonged *rajasic* acceleration: industrial revolution, colonial expansion, capitalist rivalry, military-industrial escalation, and technological mastery. Liberal trade regimes and multilateral institutions emerged as moderating architectures within this dynamism.

Yet prolonged *rajas* without tempering generates strain. Growth imperatives harden into anxiety. Competitive advantage becomes dominance-restoration rhetoric. Security doctrines amplify threat perception. Electoral systems reward mobilisation over moderation. Economic integration, once seen as guarantor of mutual gain, becomes a vector of leverage and coercion. Strategic autonomy shifts from ideological aspiration to risk management.

If every state fortifies itself without coordination, fragmentation deepens.

The strategic question, therefore, is not how to halt motion, but how to discipline it.

Classical thought distinguishes between unbridled *rajas* — restless, expansionary, easily inflamed — and *Shanta Rajasam*, energy pacified without being extinguished. *Shanta Rajasam* denotes disciplined dynamism: ambition channelled toward constructive, proportionate, and ultimately *sattvic* outcomes.

Applied to statecraft, this implies defence capability without adventurism; industrial policy without mercantilist paranoia; technological innovation within ethical guardrails; and strategic autonomy without rhetorical escalation. Middle powers must therefore cultivate *Shanta Rajasam*, neither imitating hegemonic aggression nor retreating into passivity, but consciously moderating acceleration through institutional restraint.

⁸ *Bhagavad Gita*, chap. 14; see also S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, vol. 2 (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1927).

In a *rajasic* age, disciplined energy becomes a form of strategic strength.

The Structural Moment: Between Hegemony and Fragmentation

The global system today is shaped by three overlapping dynamics:

First, strategic bipolarity is reasserting itself in rivalry between Washington and Beijing, with supply chains, finance, and technology ecosystems increasingly securitised. This is not Cold War replication; the emerging bipolarity is techno-economic rather than ideological, with infrastructure, finance, and technological ecosystems constituting the primary theatres of competition.

Second, multilateral institutions, including the United Nations system and Bretton Woods architecture, face declining legitimacy and operational paralysis.

Third, technological acceleration redistributes power faster than regulatory frameworks can adapt. This produces fragmentation without collapse: competitive interdependence in which great powers pursue assertive agendas while smaller states hedge.

Carney adds a fourth layer: the erosion of ritualised belief in institutional constraint. If middle powers continue to “place the sign in the window”⁹ while enforcement erodes, sovereignty becomes performance rather than substance.

What Is a Middle Power?

Traditional definitions emphasise material capability: GDP scale, military expenditure, diplomatic reach. Yet capability alone does not capture systemic role. A more refined understanding combines material weight with behavioural disposition.

Middle powers such as India, Japan, the European Union, the United Kingdom, Canada, and Australia typically exhibit:

- Commitment to multilateral frameworks
- Preference for coalition-building over unilateral assertion
- Institutional density and regulatory credibility
- Normative engagement in the provision of global public goods

They cannot dictate systemic outcomes, nor are they insulated from instability. Yet they retain agenda-setting capacity and coalition leverage disproportionate to their material scale.

⁹ Carney, Address at the World Economic Forum.

In a *rajasic* environment, however, middle powers face pressure to mirror hegemonic behaviour. Competitive alignment, reactive nationalism, and prestige signalling can erode the stabilising distinctiveness that gives them influence.

Carney's warning against the "performance of sovereignty"¹⁰ is instructive: bilateral accommodation under structural asymmetry may project autonomy while entrenching dependence. Acting alone, middle powers compete for favour. Acting together, they reshape terms.

This logic points beyond *ad hoc* coordination toward a more deliberate alignment of proportionate powers.

A coalition of middle powers must remain porous to responsible expansion. Proportionate statecraft is not the preserve of any region. As cooperative practice consolidates and institutional trust deepens among participating states, the MPG may gradually extend to include countries such as Brazil and Nigeria, societies whose demographic vitality and regional leadership confer systemic relevance. Such inclusion must be evolutionary and criteria-based, grounded in shared commitment to disciplined governance and multilateral responsibility. Expansion undertaken in this manner strengthens legitimacy without diluting coherence.

Maṇḍala and Variable Geometry

The strategic thought of Kautilya offers an illuminating lens. *Mandala* theory, articulated in the *Arthashastra*, begins with a sober premise: proximity generates rivalry.¹¹ States exist in concentric circles of alignment and opposition; today's adversary may be tomorrow's partner. Alliances are situational, and prudence, not sentiment, governs alignment. In this respect, Kautilya stands in conversation with Thucydides.¹²

Yet *maṇḍala* is not amoral opportunism. Kautilya is explicit that internal consolidation precedes external projection. Fiscal strength, administrative coherence, and social stability form the foundation of strategic credibility. Prestige without capacity invites vulnerability; assertion without preparation courts overextension. Prudence is therefore not caution alone, but calibrated ambition grounded in material resilience.

This insight resonates sharply in a system marked by techno-economic bipolar rivalry and institutional erosion. Rigid bloc alignment magnifies exposure; isolation forfeits influence. What emerges instead is variable geometry: differentiated coalitions across trade, defence, climate, and technology governance; diversified partnerships; autonomy exercised through diversification rather than withdrawal.

¹⁰ Carney, Address at the World Economic Forum.

¹¹ Kautilya, *Arthashastra*, trans. R. Shamasastri (Bangalore: Government Press, 1915).

¹² Roger Boesche, *The First Great Political Realist: Kautilya and His Arthashastra* (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2002).

The coalition logic articulated by Mark Carney mirrors this *mandala* sensibility. Alignment is contextual rather than ideological. Cooperation varies by domain. The objective is neither moral theatre nor reflexive balancing, but the maintenance of structural equilibrium amid rivalry.

Maṇḍala thus refines contemporary realism. It accepts competition as structural, yet situates statecraft within *rajadharma*, the duty to preserve order and prosperity. Power is exercised with calibration; treaties are instruments rather than illusions; economic vitality underwrites autonomy.

Such civilisational realism offers middle powers a vocabulary free from nostalgia and free from fatalism. It neither denies competition nor romanticises it. It disciplines it.

Dharma as Strategic Counterweight

Dharma refers to order, duty, proportion, and right conduct appropriate to role and context. Applied to statecraft, it implies power exercised within *maryādā*, bounded order.

Dharma reframes middle power agency as stewardship. It is structural discipline: authority aligned with responsibility; ambition proportionate to capability.

Carney's notion of "value-based realism" converges with this logic. It rejects naïve multilateral nostalgia while resisting pure transactionalism. Domestic strength underwrites principled diplomacy. States earn the right to ethical stances by reducing vulnerability to retaliation.

In a *rajasik* age, Dharma functions as counterweight. It does not suppress dynamism. It regulates it.

For middle powers, this entails:

- Sustaining and reforming institutions
- Mediating conflict rather than amplifying polarity
- Building domestic resilience
- Exercising influence commensurate with capacity

Confucian harmony, European rule-of-law traditions, and Commonwealth proceduralism reflect analogous commitments to proportionate authority.

Dharma as Prior to Artha

Economic vitality remains indispensable to state strength. Trade expansion, technological leadership, and GDP growth expand strategic options and enhance resilience. Yet classical statecraft is unambiguous in its hierarchy: Dharma precedes *Artha*. Without institutional integrity, growth becomes extractive;

without ethical restraint, prosperity corrodes legitimacy; without proportional governance, expansion generates instability.

In contemporary terms, this means that regulatory coherence, fiscal discipline, rule-of-law credibility, and social trust must anchor economic ambition. Industrial policy detached from institutional accountability breeds oligarchy. Financial expansion without prudential oversight invites crisis. Technological scaling without ethical constraint produces fragmentation. Durable *Artha* emerges only when disciplined by Dharma.

For middle powers, this ordering is decisive. Their influence will not derive merely from economic scale, but from the credibility of their governance. When Dharma anchors *Artha*, growth stabilises order. When *Artha* outruns Dharma, acceleration becomes brittle. In a *rajasic* international environment, institutional proportion is the true multiplier of power.

The true test of this hierarchy lies not in abstraction, but in the conduct of rising powers navigating acceleration without institutional erosion.

India and the Threshold of Moderation

India's own trajectory reflects a movement from fragmentation and subordination toward disciplined consolidation and economic dynamism. Post-independence nation-building required intensive institutional effort: food-security, industrial foundations, constitutional stability. Economic liberalisation in the 1990s accelerated integration and entrepreneurial vitality.

In entering a distinctly *rajasic* phase — defined by innovation, ambition, and global assertion — it encounters the familiar temptation of prestige-driven escalation. The enduring question, as for other rising powers, is how to moderate acceleration without surrendering momentum.

The *dharmic* test lies in anchoring ambition within institutional credibility and developmental priorities.

If India mirrors hegemonic rivalry, it forfeits stabilising distinctiveness. If it retreats into caution, it relinquishes influence. Its opportunity lies in disciplined equilibrium: calibrated coalition leadership, internal strengthening, and prudent assertion consistent with mandala realism.

Toward a Sattvic Equilibrium

The deeper civilisational question before the international system is not which power dominates, but whether leading societies can consciously moderate acceleration.

We inhabit a *rajasic* age: restless, ambitious, structurally kinetic. Competition shapes incentives; technological velocity compresses deliberation; power

transitions heighten vigilance. Dynamism cannot, and should not, be eliminated. The challenge is whether acceleration can be tempered before it hardens into rupture.

The era of ritual reassurance has passed. Stability will not re-emerge through invocation of past architectures. It must be constructed through clear-eyed recognition of power realities, sustained domestic resilience, and coalition-based influence.

A *sattvic* equilibrium does not imply passivity. It denotes clarity within power, restraint within strength, and proportion within ambition. It requires institutions capable of absorbing rivalry without cascading escalation.

Middle powers occupy a decisive position in this transition. They lack hegemonic insulation yet retain non-dominant credibility. Acting in concert, they can weave dense networks of cooperation — issue-based coalitions, shared standards, diversified trade and technology partnerships — that dampen volatility without denying competition.

Realism ensures survival. Equilibrium enables flourishing.

From Raja Dharma to Viśva Dharma

Raja Dharma has traditionally referred to the duty of rulers to preserve order, ensure prosperity, and administer justice within their domain. In an interconnected and technologically fused world, that responsibility cannot remain territorially confined. The scale of interdependence, financial, digital, ecological, and strategic, demands an outward extension of duty.

This extension may be described as *Viśva Dharma*: responsibility toward the stability of the wider international order.¹³

Viśva Dharma does not dilute sovereignty; it dignifies it. A state that pursues growth while destabilising its environment weakens its own foundations. A power that instrumentalises institutions without sustaining them erodes the architecture upon which it also depends. Middle powers, by virtue of their scale and embeddedness, are uniquely positioned to embody this transition, aligning domestic institutional strength with global responsibility. Climate governance, digital standards, multilateral reform, and conflict mediation are not moral exhibitionism; they are structural duties in a densely interdependent system.

In a period defined by competitive assertion, *Viśva Dharma* offers neither utopianism nor denial. It offers proportion, the conscious alignment of power with systemic responsibility.

The Dharma of middle powers, therefore, is not to extinguish *rajas* but to discipline it; not to withdraw from rivalry but to moderate it; not to claim moral

¹³ Hedley Bull, *The Anarchical Society: A Study of Order in World Politics* (London: Macmillan, 1977).

superiority but to practice proportional leadership. The future of global order may depend less on dominance than on the capacity to align power with wisdom.

Such alignment would mark the emergence of a *sāttvic* equilibrium.
